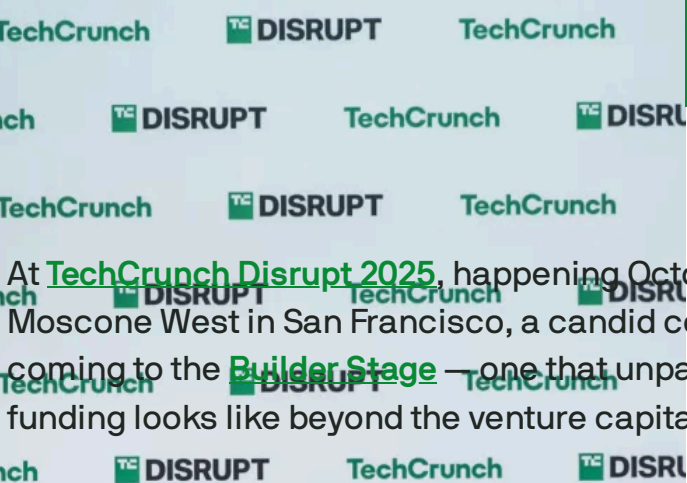




STARTUPS



## How founders are ditching VC norms and finding capital on their own terms at TechCrunch Disrupt 2025



At [TechCrunch Disrupt 2025](#), happening October 27-29 at Moscone West in San Francisco, a candid conversation is coming to the [Builder Stage](#) — one that unpacks what startup funding looks like beyond the venture capital echo chamber.



## Funding routes that don't start in the Valley

IMAGE CREDITS: SLAVA BLAZER PHOTOGRAPHY

Founders today have more capital paths than ever. But how do you navigate them — and know which one actually supports your growth? In this session, hear from Erik Allebest, the CEO and co-founder of [Chess.com](#); Gale Wilkinson, the founder and managing partner at [VITALIZE](#); and Kay Makishi, vice president at [Lupoff/Stevens Family Office](#). Each brings a different perspective on how to raise money without giving up your vision or your cap table.

Whether you're bootstrapping, tapping family offices, or building through angel networks, this discussion breaks down what's working now, what to avoid, and how to choose the approach that fits your goals.

## Meet the speakers carving out new funding lanes

[Erik Allebest](#) turned a college passion into Chess.com, now the leading platform for players and learners with over 165

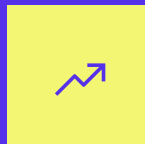
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- The best dating apps aren't even dating apps

million users. Built without chasing venture capital, it's a bootstrapped success story in a league of its own.

[Gale Wilkinson](#) has made 50 personal angel investments and led more than \$80 million in early-stage funding across 150 startups. She's a WorkTech expert, a champion for diversity in venture, and a go-to voice for founders who want capital that shares their values.

[Kay Makishi](#) brings a cross-border lens as a key investor at a New York-based family office. With experience spanning U.S. and Japanese markets, she offers rare insight into how high-net-worth individuals and families back startups for impact, not just returns.

## Skip the status quo and fund smarter

There's more than one way to get to your next round. Don't miss this [session](#) that shows how founders are funding differently — and winning. [Grab your pass](#) to TechCrunch Disrupt 2025 today to save up to \$675 in ticket savings, and be in the room with 10,000+ startup and VC leaders.

**TC**

### Tech and VC heavyweights join the Disrupt 2025 agenda

Netflix, ElevenLabs, Wayve, Sequoia Capital — just a few of the heavy hitters joining the Disrupt 2025 agenda. They're here to deliver the insights that fuel startup growth and sharpen your edge. Don't miss the 20th anniversary of TechCrunch Disrupt, and a chance to learn from the top voices in tech — [grab your ticket now](#) and save up to \$675 before prices rise on August 7.

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## STARTUPS



# Term sheets, traction, and truth bombs: Inside the Series A mindset at TechCrunch Disrupt 2025

TechCrunch Events — 7:30 AM PDT · August 1, 2025

At [TechCrunch Disrupt 2025](#), taking place October 27-29 at Moscone West in San Francisco, we're getting real about what it takes to land a Series A in today's market — no smoke, no mirrors, just the unfiltered perspective from the people signing the checks.



# Series A has changed — here's how to win in 2026

This [Builder Stage session](#) brings together three power players in early-stage investing: Katie Stanton ([Moxxie Ventures](#)), Thomas Krane ([Insight Partners](#)), and Sangeen Zeb ([GV](#)). They've seen thousands of decks, led major rounds, and helped steer startups from scrappy beginnings to breakout scale.

This conversation goes deeper than the headlines. From the metrics that matter and how to tell your growth story, to what causes investors to walk away — you'll hear what actually moves a pitch from “maybe” to “we're in.”

## Meet the VCs who know how to spot a rocket ship

[Katie Stanton](#) brings a track record most operators only dream of. From Twitter and the Obama White House to backing more than 100 early-stage companies like Airtable, Calm, and Carta, she's built Moxxie Ventures on conviction and founder-first instincts.

[Thomas Krane](#) has spent over a decade at Insight Partners, climbing from analyst to managing director while backing some of the biggest names in software and cybersecurity. With IPO wins like JFrog and SentinelOne, he knows what scalable traction looks like — and how to fund it.

[Sangeen Zeb](#) is a general partner at GV with an eye for enterprise and AI. His board work spans companies like

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Vercel and Harvey, and he's helped lead investments in some of the most talked-about growth stories in tech.

# Your Series A isn't just a round — it's a reset

The market is tighter, the stakes are higher, and this is the session founders can't afford to miss. Learn what it takes to raise on your terms and build for the long game. Lock in your [seat at TechCrunch Disrupt 2025](#) now to save up to \$675 and join 10,000+ startup and VC leaders in the room where deals — and futures — get made.

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## STARTUPS



# Do startups still need Silicon Valley? Hear from the founders and funders challenging old assumptions at TechCrunch Disrupt 2025

TechCrunch Events — 7:30 AM PDT · July 28, 2025

As the startup world descends on San Francisco for [TechCrunch Disrupt 2025](#) — happening October 27-29 at Moscone West — one question looms large: Does building in Silicon Valley still give founders an edge? With 10,000+ startup and VC leaders gathering for this milestone Disrupt, the conversation around access, geography, and opportunity has never been more timely.

On the [Builders Stage](#), Anh-Tho Chuong (Lago), David Hall (Revolution), and Heather Doshay (SignalFire) lead a must-attend session for anyone looking to scale smart in today's startup landscape.

[Register now to save up to \\$675](#) before July ends and to join this (and many more sessions).



Latest in Startups

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# Why this conversation matters now

As distributed teams, regional hubs, and global fundraising become more normalized, founders are increasingly asking if their ZIP code actually gives them an edge. Does being in the Bay Area still open the right doors? Or has the playing field finally leveled?

This [session](#) brings together startup veterans and seasoned investors who've built and backed companies across the country — and well beyond it. They'll dig into what access looks like in 2025, how remote collaboration has evolved post-pandemic, and where true opportunity lies for emerging founders.

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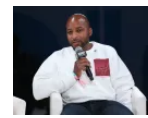
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How to actually raise a seed round: Actionable advice from top investors at TechCrunch Disrupt 2025

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Figma's IPO success is 'a little bit of a meme stock,' says Sapphire Ventures' Jai Das

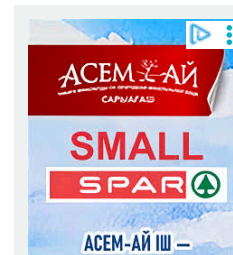
Rebecca Bellan,  
Theresa Loconsolo  
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Payment platform Lava raises \$5.8M to build digital wallets for the 'agent-native economy'

Dominic-Madori Davis  
- 16 hours ago



Fund, he's helped build a portfolio that spans the country — backing bold founders in places often overlooked by coastal VCs.





## Tech and VC heavyweights join the Disrupt 2025 agenda

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[Heather Doshay](#) knows how to scale people-first organizations from the inside. As a partner at [SignalFire](#) and former VP of People at Webflow, she's seen how the hiring landscape has shifted for startups outside the Valley — and what it takes to build standout teams in a distributed world.

## Join the debate at Disrupt

Whether you're building from a big city, a small town, or somewhere in between, this session will offer a fresh perspective on where startup success really comes from. Find out what still matters, what doesn't, and how to build your network — no matter your location.

Catch this panel live on the [Builders Stage](#) at Disrupt 2025, happening October 27-29 at Moscone West in San Francisco. Tickets are moving fast, and prices increase after July — [register now to save up to \\$675](#) and lock in your spot.



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# How startups are rewriting the late-stage playbook at TechCrunch Disrupt 2025

TechCrunch Events — 9:00 AM PDT · July 9, 2025

The rules of growth have changed. At [TechCrunch Disrupt 2025](#), happening October 27-29 at Moscone West in San Francisco, 10,000+ startup and VC leaders will gather to explore how founders are adapting in a market that looks nothing like it did five years ago. And on October 27, on the premier industry stage [Going Public](#), David George of Andreessen Horowitz will take the mic for a fireside chat focused on one of the biggest questions facing founders today — how do you scale and succeed when the old rules no longer apply?

IMAGE CREDITS: NOAM GALAI / GETTY IMAGES



## What happens when your company stays private longer?

Startups today can reach multibillion-dollar valuations, cash out early employees, and stay private far longer than their predecessors. But those benefits come with trade-offs. Late-

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stage founders now face a new set of expectations around capital efficiency, liquidity, and growth strategy. This fireside chat with [David George](#), general partner at Andreessen Horowitz, will unpack what it really takes to build enduring companies in today’s VC landscape.

George leads the Growth investing team at a16z and has backed some of the most iconic tech names of the last decade, including Airbnb, Slack, Opendoor, and Uber. His insight into how capital is deployed — from early rounds to late-stage funding and secondary markets — offers founders a rare look behind the curtain at what growth investors are looking for now.

## Why this conversation matters now

With fewer IPOs, increased scrutiny on burn, and more capital staying private longer, today’s late-stage companies are navigating a totally different set of incentives. This session will explore how the IPO window is shifting, what role secondaries play in employee liquidity, and how startups can set themselves up to weather longer timelines while still moving toward big outcomes.

Don’t miss this conversation with one of the most experienced growth investors in the game. [Join 10,000 tech, startup, and VC leaders on October 27 at the Going Public Stage](#) at TechCrunch Disrupt 2025. [Secure your spot and save up to \\$675](#) before prices go up.

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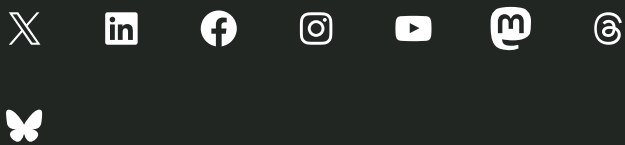
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